other reason, of course, was to make sure that eastern UP knew that Varanasi was now the new political capital of the country. And Modi its putative emperor.

Modi landed at Varanasi's Lal Bahadur Shastri airport a little before 11 a.m. He was taken by chopper to the BHU campus, then driven to the statue of Pandit Madan Mohan Malaviya, Varanasi's most revered freedom fighter. After the garlanding of the statue, the chopper took him to the Kashi Vidyapeeth where he garlanded a statue of Sardar Patel, and then set off in an open truck towards the collector's office. On a normal day, the journey would not have taken more than half an hour. That day, it took almost four hours. BJP leader Ravi Shankar Prasad, who was accompanying Modi in the truck with Shah, says it brought back memories of the anti-Indira JP andolan in the 1970s. 'I had never seen this kind of frenzied enthusiasm during an election, never,' he later told me.

My colleague Bhupendra Chaubey was on the ground while I was in the studio. In the studio, we were a little sceptical—we thought the crowds may have been hired. But Bhupendra had a different take. 'This was not a paid janata. The atmosphere was festive, people had come because they just wanted to catch a glimpse of Modi. I met someone who had taken a six-hour bus journey from Bihar just so that he could take a photo of Modi!' he said in astonishment.

Rose petals were showered on the truck, youngsters sported saffron caps and Modi T-shirts and masks, thousands lined every street corner. It was a political Maha Kumbh. And it was being played out live on television. The news agency ANI had as many as seven 3G satellite units along the route just to ensure that no image was missed. In the studio, my producer kept asking me if we should move away and show pictures of voting taking place in other parts of India that day. 'Shahrukh Khan has come to vote in Mumbai—should we cut to him?' she asked. I thought about it for a moment, and then sighed, 'I guess the real Bollywood show is being played out in Varanasi today with a star who has become even bigger than Shahrukh!'